

THEATRE

Venith at last then came to Fuera. Fuera sat in their chair and looked upon him with no interest, their eyes calm and body stiff as stone. Many had come to them before, hands trembling, voices pleading, bending and groveling, offering treasures, lives, promises, and Fuera had turned them all away.

But Venith did not bow. He did not beg. He instead pointed his finger, long and sharp, and his voice cut through the stillness like a blade.

He said, "Look now at the state of the world. How Serna brings about a great peace, a still and forever time approaching. Soon, Aster himself will fall, and then Serna will conspire with Terra and Entropy and all the mortal beings of the world. They will whisper, as they always have, to fight against you, their most hated enemy. You who take their parents, their wives, their children. They have always hated you most of all, and when they are done they will come here. They will take from you your power over death, they will end the cycle, and then all will be still forever. They will bring back those you have taken for themselves, these selfish and greedy people. Let me help you, and I will make the balance return to what it once was."

Fuera thought upon this a long time, sitting in their chair, the hands folded, the stillness of their body unbroken. They knew one alone could not upset the balance, and yet they had watched, with eyes that saw all, the scales sway ever so slightly in one direction, and it troubled them. But it always returned, it always would, it could not be changed, it had always been this way, and Fuera knew this.

Yet few were those who came now to beg and plead and cry before them. Few, and weaker than ever, and Fuera was truly a sadistic one. Let it always be said that death is cruel, for Fuera was the source of it. They gave life to the world, and loved its beauty, the laughter of children, the bloom of forests, the spark of the first stars — but they loved ever more to take it away, to squeeze it from the world, to twist it in their hands, to see despair writ upon the faces of the living. And now the cruelty rose higher, more than ever before. If not for their own amusement, if not for the exquisite joy of seeing one clever enough to ask and bold enough to manipulate, they would grant him this power. And he would make a wonderful show, a theatre of the gods, a stage of suffering and delight, and all the low would lie before his chair in fear, awe, and trembling.

So Fuera gave Venith the power of the randomness of life and death: to strike the young without reason, to prolong the suffering of the old, to lift the low-born to greatness and tumble the high-born into ruin. When fortune faltered, when the just were taken too soon, when death's laughter claimed the undeserving — all of this, all of it, now bent beneath his will.

And now Venith was done with his works, and smiled the widest smile. He went to his home to work.

— Spell, *Venith's Grand Lie*